stillness in woe

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33118054.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), mentioned bow and glimmer

Additional Tags:
Adventure Time AU, Angst, simon and betty : (, uhhh death? technically? perhaps??, dont have to know AT for this to hurt (i think?), come along with me but make it catradora, ice king crown is sword of protection

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2021-08-08 Words: 1,810 Chapters: 1/1

stillness in woe

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33118054.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), mentioned bow and glimmer

Additional Tags:
Adventure Time AU, Angst, simon and betty : (, uhhh death? technically? perhaps??, dont have to know AT for this to hurt (i think?), come along with me but make it catradora, ice king crown is sword of protection

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2021-08-08 Words: 1,810 Chapters: 1/1

stillness in woe

by maguk

Summary

"It's not working," Adora muttered to herself. She looked down. The familiar sensation of magic coursing through her veins was absent, the runestone dark. Her body went cold. "Catra, what did you do?"

"I did what had to be done," Catra replied.

****

hey, you know that one scene where simon and betty were being digested in the stomach of the physical embodiment of dissonance? yeah, that one.

Notes

this is for rhys. you know what you did. also dia.

title from purity ring yet again.

if you haven't seen adventure time, for context, golb is chaos. it is a being that embodies dissonance that will rip apart the structure of the world because that is basically its very purpose. think like greek chaos god but like red and with multiple eyes that was summoned into their world.

i forced someone who has no background knowledge of the show to read this (thanks claire) and hopefully it makes enough sense if you want to enjoy it without knowing. this is a niche one, but i have no regrets.

See the end of the work for more notes

"Sometimes you get so close to someone you end up on the other side of them." - Richard Siken

"She came out of the air and now she's returned to it. Wherever she is I can't go there." - Jeanette Winterson

"What about a person? Can a person be haunted? - Kentucky Route Zero

---

The air around Adora sizzled and moved. With each consecutive static pulse through her surroundings, it was like the filter over her mind dropped, and with that clarity came recognition. After the final click, she was confronted with a face, one she hadn't seen in a thousand years. "Catra?"

Catra took a step closer towards Adora, tears filling her eyes. "It's so good to see you, Adora."

"You're here," Adora laughed in disbelief. "You're really here." She surged forward, taking Catra into her arms. Adora pulled back to admire the reality of her face. Each freckle back in her life. Each loving look in her eyes. Everything she had lost in front of her.

The ground beneath them shifted, and Catra stumbled forward against Adora's chest. There was no exit. Each of the walls around them were red, and smooth. She could make out the shape, a large and barren box, devoid of characteristics other than it being undeniably consuming. With every second, the walls inched closer, like it was beating. Her mind dipped back into the haze as she reached a hand towards her back, fingers wrapping around the hilt of her sword.

"I've got this. Don't worry." Adora said with an anxious smile. She lifted it high into the air and spoke, "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Nothing. “It’s not working,” Adora muttered to herself. She looked down. The familiar sensation of magic coursing through her veins was absent, the runestone dark. Her body went cold. “Catra, what did you do?”

“I did what had to be done,” Catra replied, voice purposefully measured. She looked around the slowly closing space, and Adora could see her chest heaving in fear.

It was all coming together now. Adora’s head was spinning, as the missing pieces interlocked. The sword. She-Ra. The kingdoms. The war. The magic. The fucking physical embodiment of chaos whose body they were currently being dissolved in. Who she was as Adora and who she was as She-Ra collided into one, and her own heart sank. While together in mind, she was split in two.

Catra had mentioned something briefly before She-Ra left and Adora came to —that Golb was slowly breaking them down to their essential forms, piece by piece. She looked at Catra, and gone were the stolen yellow hat and magical potions that she had grown accustomed to seeing dangling off of her belt. Her hair was longer, in the ponytail Adora had made for her when she got too hot on their summer bike rides. Her shirt was the one she had worn the first night Adora told her she loved her. A culmination of a life spent by each other's sides.

Adora threw the sword onto the ground and began pacing. She looked down at her clothing. For as many years as she galavanted around in that stupid pair of shorts and tiara, she still recognized the red jacket she found herself in. She had worn it on their first date together, in a world so similar, but so different. At their purest form, they were two people in love.

Adora held both of Catra’s hands in her own. “Why did you do this?”

“You left me,” Catra replied, her voice strained and her conviction draining.

In her own mind again, Adora couldn’t escape her past. Catra wasn’t wrong. She drew the sword that night to protect her, and in that slip of her own mind, hurt her. The sword had started as something small: a little sliver of her life, a little obsession to fuel her days. She spent so much time researching and unraveling, when the truth of it all was beyond what words could tell her. The first day she picked up the sword, truly held it in her hands, let the power feel its way through her limbs, was the initial nail into her coffin. It was too late when she realized the memory lapses. Awareness of each chunk of time that vanished when Adora slipped away and She-Ra came through. Within the sword was something bigger than herself, a being that ached to exist and possess. But the advantages of wielding the sword —the strength, the energy, the magic —it was intoxicating. It was all too late. The next morning, Catra woke up to a half empty bed, and Adora, having slipped through that portal, was centuries away.

In all of it, Adora remembered the consumption of her self, the way the sword leached into who she was until she was nothing else but a vessel of who the sword needed to be. It was slow, and it was agonizing —a possession of her mind and body. But above all, it was against her will.

If Adora had a say, she would have died in that great fiery end of their world by Catra’s side. She would have never left Glimmer, young and alone in the beginnings of some worser existence. The sword forced her hand. She would die before she hurt someone she loved again. “I had no choice.”

“What was I supposed to do?” Catra sobbed. “Can’t you see? As She-Ra lived, you died. I couldn’t lose you. Not again.”

Adora couldn’t blame her. In her short moments as herself, the pain she felt missing Catra threatened to swallow her whole. As

much as she despised the sensation of not being in control, it was almost preferred to living in a conscious world without her. She could go on, live her life, so long as she never knew who she was missing. The only way to live in a world without Catra was to not know that she was. A life lived in ignorance. At least now if she died, she did so as Adora, and no one else. At least if she died, she could do so as she was always meant to, right by Catra's side.

"It's hopeless, isn't it?"

Catra's eyes flashed to the sword, and her expression shifted, her voice shaking. "I think so."

"If this is the end, the most important thing is that we are here together." Adora held Catra close, her head tucked under her chin. It was like it was always meant to be, the two of them at the end of it all, the death she had cheated Catra out of by choosing what she thought was right.

Just as she accepted her overdue death, Adora could make out the growing voices on the other side of the heart wall, getting louder and louder. "Do you hear that?" She asked.

A hole began forming in the direction of the sound. As the song continued, her heart started pounding. Bow. Glimmer. They were coming for them. Tears sprang to her eyes. Adora pulled back and grabbed the sides of Catra's face, holding her jaw. She kissed her gently, and her hands shook.

"We are going to be okay. I'm going to get us home, okay." She made her way towards Bow's outstretched hand now reaching into the beast.

Catra shook her head. "This world will end unless Golb is destroyed."

“We can figure it out together, alright? But we have to leave now,” Adora turned to her friends, flying on the back of Swiftwind just within reach.

“You have to hurry! It’s closing!” Bow shouted to her and reached to grab her around the middle of her body. She felt a tug as Catra refused to move.

“The sword. I have to make this wish.”

“We can make the wish when we are safe. Please, Catra,” Adora begged.

Catra kissed her again and spoke, “I’m sorry. For everything.”

“Wait, Catra, no!” Adora yelled as Catra’s wrist slipped from her grasp. As she got pulled further and further out of her certain death, she saw Catra sprinting towards the abandoned sword on the ground. Bow’s arms held tight around her waist as she thrashed, trying still to fight her way back.

Dust flew up as her body collided with the ground, knocking the air from her lungs. She gasped and scrambled to her feet, watching as a supernova exploded from the place Golb once hovered, like death looming over them all. She could hear her own voice screaming, but the name never reached her ears.

In the aftermath, a new creature emerged, the same yet different. With two new eyes fixed above the original. One yellow, one blue.

The runestone sparked alive. Catra passed the sword back and forth in her hands. The hilt was soft and worn. Her fingers sat

mismatched from the way the material had molded for Adora. Never again.

Adora had been studying it when their whole lives crumbled, a task Catra took on as it slowly consumed Adora's mind. She was not the first to wield it, but if Catra had anything to say about it, she would be the last. In the deepest parts of her heart, she had some pity for it. It's original purpose had merit, a wish-granter at its purest form. Here in the heart of Golb, it could return once more.

Catra had torn the world to shreds. She came to Etheria with a cause, to get Adora back. She let everything burn in her wake to get it. Nothing else mattered or ever would. And as much as she could feel her mind slipping, she wouldn't stop. Couldn't stop. She saw the glimmer of Adora hidden deep down in the recesses of She-Ra, and she would fight to her last breath, anything to free her.

To lose Adora was a fate worse than death. But it was something she had lived through before. Catra dropped to the ground walls pressed against her shoulders. She gripped the sword in her two hands, and she saw her face reflected in the runestone. "I wish to banish Golb from this world."

The air rumbled, and the confines of the organ constricted further and further. Panic flooded her body.

"Oh no, oh no, no." She hit the center of the stone with the heel of her palm and tried to calm her breathing. "I wish that Golb would disappear!"

Catra had lived one life too many. Her time had been ticking long before Golb was summoned, long before she arrived in Etheria. It had started that fateful day Adora first picked up the sword. But things were different this time. Adora was free and alive. For now.

She closed her eyes. “I wish for the power to keep Adora safe.”

A bright light washed over her, and Catra ceased to be.

End Notes

okay additional characters explanation. glimmer was found by adora like marcy but is more like PB in the whole kingdom aspect. bow is a hero like finn. i kept him out of this scene to make it parallel the heart more, and also because the idea of reckless hero adora like finn makes me feral, so i wanted to save some of those aspects.

im just very into the idea of adora losing herself to she-ra and catra driving herself mad to the point of throwing her whole life away just for adora to gain freedom from it.

you can find me on twitter @ pericyt3

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!